

Read: Philippians 1:3-11

Bringing It Home

Philippians 1:3-6

I thank my God every time I remember you. In all my prayers for all of you, I always pray with joy because of your partnership in the gospel from the first day until now, being confident of this, that he who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus.

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Do you know what it means to “Finish strong”?

If a runner doesn't finish the race strong, they might slow down at the finish line and lose the race. If you give up on homework halfway through, your grade will suffer. It's important not just to work hard but to work hard all the way up until the task is complete. That's why coaches encourage runners to finish strong and teachers encourage students to work hard on the whole assignment.

When Paul prayed for the church in Philippi, he prayed for a strong finish. He wanted his partnership with the Philippians to last all the way to the very end so that everyone in that congregation could enjoy a blessed reunion with him in heaven someday. But Paul isn't playing the part of coach, or teacher for the Philippians. He played the role of pastor, and he prayed that *God* would finish strong.

God is the one who began the good work in each one of us: he gave us faith to believe in him. And because God is the one who began this faith in us, he is the one that keeps us in it—and he is the one that will bring it all the way to completion. What does it look like when faith reaches its completion? It looks like heaven! One day, we will be able to see Jesus with our own eyes and see God face-to-face. In heaven, we no longer need faith. Our faith becomes sight! So, Paul prays that all his beloved church members would reach that day—he prays that God would complete their faith and bring them to heaven forever.

The Advent season is a wonderful time of year to pray for a strong finish to faith. As we look ahead to Jesus' return, we have confidence in knowing that Jesus is the one who began the good work in us...and he is the one who carries it to completion. We'll get to bring it home to heaven because of Jesus' perfect work!

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- How is life like a race?
- What is waiting for us across the finish line of the race?

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- Paul thanked God for the partnership of the Philippians. Whose partnership do you thank God for?
- Jesus came to this earth to finish the work of saving us. What will he do when he comes again?

Questions for Middle School and Above

- Why is it so great to have other Christians running this race alongside us, like Paul and the Philippians?
- Why is it so comforting to know that our finish doesn't depend on us, but on God?

Closing Prayer:

God in heaven, we pray for a strong finish. Help us to run this race of life. Bring us across the finish line. We are so excited to see you with our own eyes! Amen.